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Our Political Science Study Programmes in a Comparative Perspective

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1. Introduction

The purpose of this report is to offer a brief overview of political science study programmes offered at other universities. We were given this task by Birgitta Niklasson, director of studies, as part of the ongoing quality assurance work in the Department of Political Science at the University of Gothenburg. The idea is to compare the study programmes offered in Gothenburg with those offered elsewhere, to draw inspiration and identify the ways in which our programmes are distinctive.

We would like to make a terminological clarification at the outset. Some degrees connected to the study programmes included in this report are named Bachelor/Master of Science whereas others are named Bachelor/Master of Arts. Since nothing substantial hangs on this for the purposes of this report, we use the abbreviation “BA” and “MA” throughout.

Selection criteria

To make this task manageable, we had to employ stringent selection criteria. As is standard, we include the other members of the “big four” universities in Sweden: Lund, Stockholm, and Uppsala. These are the departments with which Gothenburg traditionally compares itself domestically, and although we know that we do not compete much with these departments at the BA level, we do compete on the MA level (Andersson & Lilleste, 2023). We also include what we take to be other prominent departments of political science in Scandinavia. While one could always discuss exactly which Scandinavian universities to include, we found it obvious to include Aarhus and Oslo. We also chose to include Bergen since its political science profile matches that of Gothenburg and there are strong links, historically as well as in the present, between the two universities.

However, in keeping with our ambition to draw international comparisons, we have also looked at universities outside of Scandinavia. More specifically, our idea was to include European universities which rank higher than Gothenburg in the well-known Shanghai ranking for political science. In 2023, the Shanghai ranking had Gothenburg at place 16 in the world, beaten only by Oxford (no. 4), LSE (no. 7), Aarhus (no. 11), and Amsterdam (no. 15) in Europe.¹ However, we do not include Oxford here since its lack of pure political science degrees at the bachelor level, reliance on colleges, and one-year master’s education makes it difficult to compare with a Bologna based system such as Gothenburg’s. In the end, then, from this group we chose to include the LSE, Aarhus, and Amsterdam on the BA level and Aarhus on the MA level, owing to the fact that Amsterdam and the LSE only offer one-year MA programmes. We acknowledge that it is not obvious that going by the Shanghai ranking is the best idea considering that it tracks research excellence rather than educational excellence. Still, it is reasonable to assume that strong research departments also tend to be strong places of education; and since these are universities with which Gothenburg generally wants to compare itself, going by the Shanghai ranking is as good a choice as any.

To further delimit the task, we only looked at degrees *in political science*. Many universities offer various combined degrees (e.g., history and politics; politics, philosophy, and economics). These are not covered here. Instead, we look at pure political science education, arguing that this represents the core basis on which comparisons should be made.

¹ <https://www.shanghairanking.com/rankings/gras/2023/RS0504>

What we offer here, then, is an overview of BA and MA programmes in political science among certain Swedish, Scandinavian, and European departments. An obvious question is why we do not include US departments considering that they dominate the top of the Shanghai ranking. Our initial ambition was to include a these, but we decided that the American educational system is too different from the Bologna-based one to make the comparisons meaningful.

The Nature of the Comparisons

In describing the study programmes, we remain at a fairly high level of abstraction. We want to assess what topics are being taught, the relative balance of topics, and the progression over semesters, not details such as which textbooks are used. The rationale behind this is that getting a whole-programme picture seems most relevant for identifying the ways in which Gothenburg sticks out, either positively or negatively. There is, however, one exception where we have taken a closer look at courses at the level of the individual syllabus: methods courses. There is an ongoing discussion at Gothenburg regarding not only the timing of methods courses but also how well these courses compare, in terms of sophistication, to other departments. Therefore, we offer some brief remarks about the substance of the methods courses.

2. Swedish Bachelor's programmes in Political Science

In this section, we describe, compare, and briefly assess the BA programmes in political science at Gothenburg, Lund, Stockholm, and Uppsala.

2.1 Gothenburg

Our own BA programme in Political Science consists of six semesters (180 credits). The programme leads to a *Degree of Bachelor of Science in Political Sciences with a major in Political Science* (politices kandidatexamen). Prospective students need to fulfil basic eligibility from upper secondary school². Around 60 students were admitted and registered to start the programme both fall 2023 and spring 2024.

Table 1 Structure of the BA programme in Political Science, University of Gothenburg (Statsvetarprogrammet, SVEP)

1 st semester	Institutions and actors in political systems (15 credits)	Political Theory (7,5 credits)	International Relations (7,5 credits)
2 nd semester	Democracy and democratization in a comparative perspective (15 credits)	Further studies in democracy (15 credits) or Prospects for environmental politics* (15 credits)	
3 rd semester	Elective subject (“minor”), core courses*** (30 credits)		
4 th semester	Elective subject (“minor”), in-depth courses*** (30 credits)		
5 th semester**	Elective courses/exchange studies/Internship (30 credits)		
6 th semester**	Methods in political science (15 credits) BA thesis (15 credits)		

Source: <https://www.gu.se/sites/default/files/2024-03/S1STV%20utbildningsplan%20fr%20H24%20240314.pdf>

Comment: *The course "Prospects for environmental politics" is only available in the spring semester.

Elective minor subjects are: Political Science: Power, Democracy, and Organization, Political Science: International Politics, Economics, Media and communication, Psychology, Sociology (including Criminology and Social psychology), and Statistics. * The order of the 5th and 6th semester can be altered.

The students study political science for three semesters and choose a minor subject field that they study for two semesters. The elective minor subjects are: Political Science: Power, Democracy, and Organization, Political Science: International Politics, Economics, Media and communication, Psychology, Sociology (including Criminology and Social psychology), and Statistics. Economics and Statistics requires Mathematics 3 from upper secondary school. One semester is for elective courses, internship, or exchange studies.

The courses during the first semester reflects the four standard subfields, or "legs", in political science. Institutions and Actors in Political Systems is a 15 credits course that combines comparative politics, Swedish politics and public administration. The two remaining courses are 7,5 credits each: Political Theory and International Relations. During the second semester,

² Basic eligibility means that you need a degree from one of the six university preparatory upper secondary programmes (Social Science, Economics, Humanities, Arts, Science, or Technology programme), or a degree from a vocational upper secondary program with Pass grade in English 6 and Swedish 2 and 3. To obtain the upper secondary degree from a university preparatory upper secondary programs, the student needs to have a pass grade (E) in 2250 of 2500 credits including Pass grades in Swedish 1, 2 and 3, English 5 and 6, Mathematics 1 and finally a Pass grade in the upper secondary project work.

students take two 15 credits courses: Democracy and Democratization in a Comparative Perspective, and either Further Studies in Democracy or Prospects for Environmental Politics. Further Studies in Democracy (in Swedish: Tematisk fördjupning) is in essence a course consisting of semi-elective tracks with three or four different themes in political science.³ Both Further Studies in Democracy and Prospects for Environmental Politics teach how to write a literature review and a research plan and is thus preparatory for the upcoming thesis work. Students also learn the concepts of variables, causal mechanisms, and operationalisations. During the third and fourth semester, the students take their subject minor or choose additional political science. Currently, the department offers one track called Democracy, Power, and Organisation.⁴ From fall 2024, the department will also offer a political science track in International Politics.⁵

During semester five or six, the students take a course on research methods and writes their BA theses. The research methods course teaches both qualitative and quantitative methods, and the course is also firmly integrated with the thesis course. The students write a first memo about their thesis idea, and this memo is used to match students with supervisors. The final examination is a paper that should include research problem, theory, research design, analytical approach, and potential results. The other assignments on the course are: The research problem; bivariate regression; case studies; interviews; experiments; qualitative text analysis; and multiple regression.

2.2 Lund

The BA programme in political science and economics in Lund starts every semester. Around 90-100 students are admitted each semester. The programme leads to a *Degree of Bachelor of Science in Politics and Economics*.

The BA programme in Political Science in Lund consists of three semesters of political science (political science 1, 2 and 3). One semester of economics is mandatory. The political science students can take a second semester of economics, or choose a course in human geography, statistics, or commercial law, or a combination of statistics and commercial law.

The first semester in political science consists of four sub-courses, 7,5 credits each, covering the basics of political science (see table 2). Introduction to political science combines the scientific study of politics and political theory. The course on political systems covers Swedish and comparative politics. The two final courses cover public administration and international politics.

The second semester in political science includes a course on Democracy, a course named Alternative Theories in Political Science which is a cover name for semi-elective courses (the students choose between three courses). The students then take a course in research methods

³ Current tracks/topics are: Gender, Gender Equality and Politics (in English); Corruption and Institutional Quality; Local Politics; and Political Participation.

⁴ Courses included are: The Delegation of Political Power (7,5 credits); Delegation to the Executive: Dilemmas and Institutional Solutions (in English, 7,5 credits); The Power of Public Administration: Problems and Possibilities (15 credits); Swedish Public Administration: Traditions, Institutions, and Politics (15 credits); and The Professional Political Scientist (15 credits).

⁵ Courses included: World Politics: Order, Governance, Cooperation, and Diplomacy; Foreign Policy Analysis; Conflict and Conflict Resolution; Institutional Development and Democratization in an International Perspective; and The Professional Political Scientist.

and writes a second semester thesis. Finally, the third semester in political science, which is placed as the fifth or sixth semester on the programme, consists of a semi-elective course and a research methods course, and these courses run parallel. The semester ends with the BA thesis.

Table 2 Structure of the Bachelor of science programme in politics and economics, Lund University (Politices kandidatprogrammet)

1 st semester	<i>Political Science, level 1 (30 credits):</i> Introduction to political science (7,5 credits) Political systems (7,5 credits) The organization and implementation of politics International politics (7,5 credits)
2 nd semester	Economics, level 1 (30 credits)
3 rd semester	Human geography/Economics/Statistics/Commercial law (30 credits) <i>or</i> Statistics (15 credits) + Commercial law (15 credits)
4 th semester	<i>Political science, level 2 (30 credits):</i> Democracy (7,5 credits) Alternatives in political science theory* (7,5 credits) Political science methods (7,5 credits) Thesis (7,5 credits)
5 th semester	Elective semester: <i>Political science level 3 (30 credits):</i> Political science methods (7,5 credits) Semi-elective course (7,5 credits)** BA thesis (15 credits) <i>or</i> Elective course/exchange studies/internship (30 credits)
6 th semester	Elective semester: <i>Political science level 3 (30 credits):</i> Political science methods (7,5 credits) Semi-elective course (7,5 credits)** BA thesis (15 credits) <i>or</i> Elective course/exchange studies/internship (30 credits)

Source: <https://www.lu.se/lubas/i-uoh-lu-SGPOL>.

Comment: *The course “Alternatives in political science theory” consists of several elective courses, examples are: Hur stater styrs, Konflikt och samverkan i internationell politik, Makt och förvaltning.

**The elective courses at the 5th/6th semester in political science are: Environmental Governance; Politisk makt och demokrati; International Relations Theory in Time and Space; Comparative Politics; Political Cinema; Utrikes- och säkerhetspolitisk analys; Europeisk integration; The Politics of Climate Change; Parties and Political Behaviour; and Institutional Complexity in World Politics. The available elective courses for each semester are decided by the department board. During political science level 3, the method course and the elective course run parallel.

The first research method course follows the research process and student train all elements from problem formulation to choosing method, connect to relevant theory, collect, and analyse empirical material. The second method course includes scientific theory, methods for quantitative and qualitative analysis (the latter are case studies, interpretive methods, normative analysis).

The content of the political science courses in Lund reflects what is commonly taught in Swedish political science, that is, what we earlier labelled the four “legs” (political theory, comparative politics, public administration and international politics), and a course deepening

the knowledge about democracy and democratization. The thing that stands out the most is that Lund has kept the second semester thesis, previously known as “B-uppsats”. Compared to Gothenburg, Lund also offers more semi-elective courses. Finally, students in Lund study two courses in parallel during Political Science 3, while there are no parallel courses in Gothenburg.

2.3 Stockholm

The BA programme in politics and economics in Stockholm starts every semester and admits around 65-70 students. The programme leads to a *Degree of Bachelor of Science with Political Science as main field of study*.

The BA programme in Stockholm consists of three semesters of political science, two semesters of economics and one elective semester (see table 3). It is also possible to major in economics. The first semester of political science introduces the sub-disciplines political theory, comparative politics, and international politics. Instead of public administration, which is included in Gothenburg, Lund and Uppsala, the students take a course on Swedish politics.

Table 3 Structure of Bachelor of science programme in economics and politics, Stockholm University (Politics kandidatprogram i nationalekonomi och statsvetenskap)

1 st semester	<i>Political science 1 (30 credits):</i> Political Theory (7,5 credits) Swedish Politics (7,5 credits) Comparative Politics (7,5 credits) International Politics (7,5 credits)
2 nd semester	Economics 1 (30 credits)
3 rd semester	<i>Political Science 2 (30 credits):</i> Perspectives on Politics (7,5 credits) Studying Democracy (7,5 credits) Two semi-elective courses (7,5 credits each)
4 th semester	Economics 2 (30 credits)
5 th semester	<i>Political science 3 (30 credits):</i> Political Science Research Methods (15 credits) BA thesis (15 credits)
6 th semester	Elective courses/exchange studies/internship

Source: <https://www.su.se/sok-kurser-och-program/snsvk-1.411586>

Comment: List of elective courses (not all courses available each semester, list of available courses communicated during the semester introduction): Gender Equality Policy in Sweden and Europe; Environmental Politics; Politiskt ledarskap och demokrati; 21st Century Populism in a Comparative Perspective; Byråkratins makt i den demokratiska staten; Jämlikhetens teori och praktik; Transnational Actors and International Organizations; Utveckling och demokratisering i tredje världen; War and Democracy in Global Politics; Human and International security; Feminism och politik; What are Human Rights?; Perspectives on Conflicts; European Politics; Security in International Relations; Social Movements and Democracy in the Third World; Demokrati och byråkrati; International Political Economy; Demokratins problem; Samtida politisk teori; Global Environmental Politics; Att kommunicera politik: bilder, makt, identitet; Inequalities of Political Participation and Representation; and Comparative Politics in Welfare States.

Students take their second semester of political science (Political Science 2) during the third semester of the programme. This semester includes the courses Perspectives on Politics, Studying Democracy, and the choice of two semi-elective courses. Perspectives on Politics provides the student with knowledge about various social science theories and the aim of the

course is to provide the students with knowledge about the relationship between the theoretical approach, research questions, study designs and expected results. The aim with the course Studying Democracy is to provide knowledge about representative democracy both from a theoretical and empirical point of view and pros and cons with representative democracy compared to other forms of democracy. The list of semi-elective courses comprises almost 30 courses, but the department decides which courses to offer every semester. Typically, 12-15 courses are offered.⁶

Political Science 3 is placed as the fifth semester and its structure is the same way as the corresponding semester for the BA programme in Gothenburg: 15 credits Research methods and 15 credits BA thesis. The course in research methods comprises both qualitative and quantitative methods as well as scientific theory, research design and different methods for data collection. Methods included are process tracing, case studies, comparative studies and mixed methods as well as statistical analysis using a software. According to the syllabus, the course is examined through two sit-down exams, an individual paper, and a number of compulsory seminars. Since the schedules and course reports are easily available at the website, we have learned that the spring 2023 course had 104 registered students⁷. Seven teachers participated as lecturers and/or seminar leaders in the course version spring 2024⁸.

A feature that stands out for the Stockholm programme is the limited choice of subject minor compared to Gothenburg, but also compared to the programmes in Uppsala and Lund. What is more impressive though is the range of semi-elective courses where students each semester can choose two of 12-15 different courses.

2.4 Uppsala

The BA programme in political science in Uppsala starts once per year, every fall, and admits around 145 students. The programme leads to the degree of *Bachelor of Science in Political Science*.

During the first semester, the student takes the four well-known introductory courses in political science (Political Science A): Political Theory; Swedish and Comparative Politics; Public Administration; and International Politics (see table 4). During Political Science B, which is placed at the fourth programme semester, the courses are Democracy's Problem, elective course and a 15 credits research method course. The course Democracy's Problem covers conceptual and normative questions connected to democracy and other regimes, empirical questions connected to democratization, and the political and economic consequences of democracy.

The elective courses range from course on EU to courses on international politics, gender and politics, comparative politics and environmental politics. Political Science C is placed as

⁶ The information about the number of courses offered have been retrieved through personal correspondence with the departments' study councillor, Åsa Sandlund on April 5, 2024. She also informed that they currently are reviewing the programme and will decrease the number of elective courses offered. One explanation to why a large number of elective courses is possible is that there are many freestanding students and students from other programmes in addition to the pol.kand students. If the Swedish and English version of Political Science 2 are counted together, the number of students is around 160, excluding exchange students.

⁷ <https://arkiv.kursvardering.su.se/document/course-report/pdf/81ffc0ac-842c-44f2-95af-a8f236694f8c?#toolbar=1>

⁸ <https://cloud.timeedit.net/su/web/stud1/ri15786Q059Z05Q685639710yZ076W7418Y61Q0Q5.html>

the fifth programme semester and consists of one additional course in research methods, an elective course, and the BA thesis.

Table 4 Structure of the Bachelor's programme in political science (politices kandidatprogrammet), Uppsala University

1 st semester	<i>Political science A (30 credits):</i> Political theory (7,5 credits) Swedish and comparative politics (7,5 credits) Public administration (7,5 credits) International politics (7,5 credits)
2 nd semester	Economics A (30 credits)
3 rd semester	Statistics (15 credits) Administrative law (15 credits)
4 th semester	<i>Political Science B (30 credits):</i> Democracy's problem (7,5 credits) Semi-elective course (7,5 credits) Research methods (15 credits)
5 th semester	<i>Political Science C (30 credits):</i> Methods (7,5 credits) Semi-elective course (7,5 credits) BA thesis (15 credits)
6 th semester	Elective courses or Internship

Source: <https://www.uu.se/utbildning/program/politices-kandidatprogram>

Comment: The politics bachelor's programme can also be studied with a major in economics, development studies, peace and conflict science, or statistics. Semester 1-3 is identical for all students disregarding of which major subject they choose. List of elective courses (list is same for semester 4 and 5): Europeiska unionens politiska system; International Politics; Förvaltningspolitik; Genus och politik i jämförande perspektiv; Genus och utveckling; historiska genealogier/samtida konvergenser; Jämförande politik; Politisk teori; Environmental Politics and its Challenges; and Svensk politik.

The first research method course, during Political Science B, comprises 15 credits and topics/methods covered are the research process, how choice of method affects the planning, execution, and results of the empirical analysis. Students learn how to use qualitative methods such as different text-based analysis of ideas, normative critique, and process tracing as well as analysis of materials based on interviews. The course examinations are a smaller sit-down exam, assignments in group and an individual assignment where the students present a research design based on an independently chosen research question. The second course in research methods corresponds to 7,5 credits and is placed during Political science C. This course includes both qualitative and quantitative methods, but with emphasis on statistical methods only. Examinations include exercise tasks presented at mandatory seminars, an individual assignment applying statistical analysis, and a sit-down exam.

2.5 Comparison between the programmes

Gothenburg's BA programme requires basic eligibility whereas the programmes in Lund, Uppsala and Stockholm require special eligibility in Mathematics 3. It should however be noted that LU, SU and UU have basic eligibility as requirement for students studying political science as a free-standing course. In other words, it is the subject combination with economics

that leads to the higher eligibility criteria to the programmes. LU, SU and UU also admit many free-standing students.⁹

Although we know that most of our students apply to our programme and other social science programmes at University of Gothenburg, we want to highlight the following: although the merit points (grades) needed to get admitted to GU are very similar to UU and LU, the fact that we have basic eligibility means that a student with Mathematics 2 could get 0,5 bonus points when applying to us. All else equal, a student with Mathematics 3, which is required at LU, SU and UU, gets zero bonus points for mathematics when applying to their programmes, but could potentially get 1 bonus point when applying with us. At LU, SU and UU, only students having *more* than Mathematics 3 (which means that they studied the science programme or technology programme during upper secondary school) would potentially get these bonus points. However, it should be noted that students also can receive these bonus merits points through courses in modern languages and English 7 and that there is a cap on the number of bonus points (+2,5). In sum, it is possible that the “true” grade among GU students is slightly lower compared to LU and UU. Stockholm has significantly lower admission grades than the other three universities (see appendix 1).

In the political science BA programmes at LU, SU and UU, the main courses are labelled political science 1, 2, and 3 or A, B, and C and the actual courses are sub-courses (delkurser). In Gothenburg, there are no sub-courses, and consequently, we don’t have any formal name for the three semesters in political science respectively. However, we still tend to label them by their old names, for example “A-kursen” or “grundkursen” or “fortsättningskursen”. The construction with a more generic course name such as Political Science 1, 2 and 3 makes it very clear for the prospective student which main subject they will study during a specific semester.

The range of semi-elective courses is much larger at LU, SU and UU compared to GU. LU, SU and UU all offer two courses 7,5 credits each (in total 15 credit semi-elective courses), either during the same semester or one course during semester 2 and one course during semester 3. In comparison to the other programmes, GU provides the most freedom of choice regarding the *subject minor* (political science, or other social science subjects), but only one choice between two semi-elective courses (15 credits each) for students studying their second semester of political science during the spring semester. As previously stated, these students can choose between Further Studies in Democracy and Prospects for Environmental Politics. However, the course Further Studies in Democracy (Tematisk fördjupning) is in essence a course consisting of three to four semi-elective courses as the students choose between different themes within the course. Thus, some of the semi-elective features at GU are hidden

⁹ Fall 2023, UU admitted 34 free-standing students, SU 142 free-standing students (including the course version in English), and LU 68. GU admitted 2 students (Source: admission statistics from www.uhr.se). Thus, at GU, almost all students are programme students (political science, or European studies with political science as minor) while the groups are much more mixed at the other departments. Email correspondence with the directors of studies in Stockholm (Jon Nyhlén) and Uppsala (Mattias Sigfridsson) (Lund never replied) also provides insights about the number HST (helårsstudieplatser/full-time study seats) which is the currency used when planning higher education: Stockholm has 794 HST on the BA level and 209 on the MA level. Uppsala has around 472 HST of which 150 is for the pol.kand programme, 100 for the pol.master programme and 177 for freestanding students/exchange students on both levels. In comparison, in Gothenburg we have 295 HST for the BA level including the free-standing students (few) and exchange students (freestanding students + exchange students is 32 HST of the 295 HST), 32 for MAPS and 28 for MAPSE. Thus, the political science education is comparatively smaller in Gothenburg compared to both Stockholm and Uppsala.

behind this course name. Lund has a similar construction with the course Alternative Theory in Political Science behind which a couple of different semi-electives courses are offered.

What positively stands out in Gothenburg is the possibility to study more political science, both with the track Democracy, Power and Organisation and the new track, International Politics. Thus, students choosing one of these tracks get one more year of political science. However, the track Democracy, Power and Organisation has had a hard time attracting students despite evaluations showing that students studying on this track are both very satisfied with the courses and are more likely to receive High pass on their BA thesis (Andersson & Wängnerud, 2021).

In the programmes at LU, SU and UU, most substantive courses are 7,5 credits, while most courses in Gothenburg are 15 credits. There are pros and cons with both, but we suspect 15 credit courses lead to larger teams of teachers as courses becomes a bit broader topic-wise, but at the same time, we haven't systematically investigated this. Longer courses also mean course coordinators need to "stand by" during a longer period.

The students at UU receive more training in research methods (22,5 credits) compared to students at GU, LU and SU (15 credits). Both LU (7,5+7,5) and UU (15+7,5) split their methods training in two courses while GU and SU have one. Although there are some differences between the contents and how much emphasis there is on different methods, students on all programmes learn both qualitative and quantitative research methods as well as the research process. Based on the syllabi, we cannot assess the content of the methods training in statistics. Also, we haven't investigated *how* methods are taught, that is, to what extent students independently applies the different methods in their assignments. There is a difference between calculating or interpreting a regression coefficient based on an example provided versus choosing your own variables and running a regression in a software and interpreting the results (the latter is used at GU). But judging from the syllabi, application of methods does occur in all courses even though it is most emphasised in the GU syllabus and the UU research methods 1 syllabus. All courses also have some form of compulsory seminars or workshops with written assignments or smaller "exercises". Sit-down exams are used as part of the examination at SU and UU, which likely is a consequence of the larger student group.

3. Foreign Bachelor's Programmes in Political Science

Leaving the Swedish context, in this section we describe, compare, and briefly assess the BA programmes at Aarhus, Amsterdam, Bergen, LSE, and Oslo.

3.1 Aarhus

The BA programme in political science in Aarhus is a three-year programme taught in Danish, with some elements of English. It admits roughly 300 students each fall. The programme follows a set structure, as shown in table 5. We translate the titles of the courses.

A few things stand out. One is that the first semester is organized in a way that postpones teaching about substantive issues in political science: following the introductory course, which gives a broad overview of political science putting an emphasis on understanding the Danish political system, the students take a pair of courses that are more about critical and scientific thinking. The programme thus front loads methods. Another noteworthy feature is that little room is given for choice: only one module in the entire programme is devoted to taking an elective course. On the other hand, the number of courses on offer for this elective module is significant. In fall 2023, students could choose between nine courses, ranging from topics like voting behaviour and the crisis of democracy in comparative perspective, to the principles for democratic inclusion and social class. These courses are sometimes given several times, other times as a one-off, and teachers have the freedom to design their own classes. The classes are given, or not, depending on whether a sufficient number of students sign up for them.

Table 5 Structure of the BA programme in Political Science, University of Aarhus

1st semester	Introduction to political science (10 ECTS)	Methods I: Design, collecting and analyzing qualitative and quantitative data (10 ECTS)	Philosophy of science (10 ECTS)
2nd semester	Political theory (5 ECTS)	Methods II: Quantitative methodology (15)	Microeconomics (10)
3rd semester	Comparative political science: states, regimes, and development (10 ECTS)	Macroeconomics (10 ECTS)	Political sociology (10 ECTS)
4th semester	Public opinion, political participation, and representation (10 ECTS)	International politics (10 ECTS)	Political institutions: Western countries, the EU, and foreign policy (10 ECTS)
5th semester	Public administration (10 ECTS)	Public policy (10 ECTS)	Elective course (10 ECTS)
6th semester	Policy evaluation (10 ECTS)	BA thesis (20 ECTS)	

Source: <https://bachelor.au.dk/statskundskab/>

While the Aarhus programme covers the core subfields of political science, it spends the least time on political theory. The programme does not allow for specialization in a minor field, but it is noteworthy that the programme includes no less than two mandatory courses in economics. The presence of a course on policy evaluation is unusual in a comparative perspective but is explained by the fact that the department at Aarhus houses a centre for policy analysis and policy evaluation.

In terms of methods, the course Methods I teaches the basic of social-scientific inquiry. It includes interpretive methods for data collection and analysis (including interviews), case studies, and quantitative methodology. Most time is spent on the quantitative part, where students are taught the difference between descriptive and causal designs, sampling, and measurement. The course does not go further than bivariate analysis. Methods II is solely focused on quantitative research and goes more in-depth. It teaches statistical inference, factorial analysis, and regression. The course is quite advanced, reaching topics such as difference-in differences design. Relevant to mention here is also the sizeable course on the philosophy of science, in which students are acquainted with various theoretical perspectives (e.g., rational choice theory, constructivism, behaviourism). The course also teaches core issues such as the actor-structure problem and the difference between methodological individualism and methodological holism. The methods courses are, however, placed far from the thesis work in the last semester.

3.2 Amsterdam

This programme can be taken either in Dutch or in English. Most students take the English-speaking version of the course. It is a paid education, with tuition ranging from EUR 2,530-5,060 per year. 600 students are admitted each fall. The programme differs from that in Gothenburg in that students take courses in parallel. The programme also contains quite many courses.

As table 6 shows, the programme has a complex structure, so let us just point out a few noteworthy features. The programme forces students to pick a specialization during the fourth semester. Currently, four specializations are offered: comparative politics; international relations; political theory; and public policy and governance. In other words, the programme offers a specialization in each of the four traditional subfields in political science. The students are then required to take “bachelor seminars” (i.e., courses) in this specialization during year three of the programme. There is a good variety of options for the students. For example, within the comparative politics specialization, there are currently seventeen 6 ECTS courses and fourteen 12 ECTS courses to choose between. These courses are highly specialized, allowing students to go in-depth with issues, with some courses being part of several specializations (e.g., the course Democracy versus Meritocracy can be taken under the comparative politics or the political theory specialization). Finally, the students are expected to write a bachelor thesis within their specialization.

Two other features are worth mentioning. First, the programme allows for taking a minor. During the fifth semester, students take “optional subjects” to the tune of 30 ECTS. These can be comprised of further in-house courses, but the department encourages using them to take a minor in one of six fields (e.g., conflict studies or global migration). These minors are open to students in general and not just political science students, increasing the economics of scale for the department. Amsterdam also allows students with sufficiently good grades to follow an honours programme, which essentially consist in taking an extra 30 credits worth of honours courses. Second, the programme runs a three-part “academic skills” course, which ramp up skills in reading, critical thinking, argumentation, writing etc. In a similar vein, the programme separates questions of design from questions of methods, introducing the former earlier than the latter. The methods course in the third semester teaches both qualitative and quantitative research. It is organized using tutorial groups and not just lectures.

Table 6 Structure of the BA programme in Political Science, University of Amsterdam

1 st semester	History of the modern world since 1750 (6 ECTS)		
	Academic skills for political scientists I (6 ECTS)		
	Introduction to political science (6 ECTS)		
		Public policy and governance (6 ECTS)	
			Research project I (6 ECTS)
2 nd semester	History of political thought (6 ECTS)		
	Academic skills for political scientists II (3 ECTS)		
	Introduction to political science research (9 ECTS)		
		International relations (6 ECTS)	
			Law and politics (6 ECTS)
3 rd semester	Academic skills for political scientists III (9 ECTS)		
	Political economy (6 ECTS)		
	Research methods (9 ECTS)		
		Democracies, autocracies and transitions (6 ECTS)	
			Research project II (6 ECTS)
4 th semester	The politics of difference (6 ECTS)		
	Electives: core modules (12 ECTS)		
		Electives (6 ECTS)	
5 th semester	Free choice electives: optional subjects (30 ECTS)		
	Bachelor seminar (6 ECTS)	Bachelor thesis project (12 ECTS)	
6 th semester			
	Bachelor seminar (12 ECTS)		

Source: <https://www.uva.nl/shared-content/programmas/en/bachelors/political-science/study-programme/study-programme.html?origin=QM8V0IIERF2uFhPGbux%2F2g>

3.3 London School of Economics and Political Science

LSE offer a range of BA programmes which combine politics with another field (e.g. economics, philosophy). Here we look at the “pure” political science programme. Currently accepting around 31 students per academic year, it comes with an annual tuition fee of £9,250-£27,192.

The programme has a different structure than a Bologna-system like Gothenburg’s, making comparisons difficult. The students are expected to take 12 “units” worth of courses and writing a BA thesis is optional to be awarded the degree (see table 7).

Table 7 Structure of the BSc programme in Political Science, London School of Economics

Year 1	Obligatory courses: ▪ Introduction to Political Theory ▪ Introduction to Political Science ▪ LSE100 (university wide interdisciplinary course on analyzing global challenges) One elective course (in-house or from another department as part of an approved list of sixteen courses)
Year 2	Three elective political science courses from a list of eleven courses One elective political science or non-political science course
Year 3	Two elective political science courses from a list of >30 courses One elective political science or non-political science course Optional: BA thesis ("dissertation")

Source: <https://www.lse.ac.uk/study-at-lse/undergraduate/degree-programmes-2024/bsc-politics>

The thing that stands out about the LSE programme is the extraordinary degree of choice accorded to students. Most of the programme consists in taking elective courses, and the department offers a rich menu of sharply formulated courses, generally taught by a single faculty member. The only reason this works from a financial perspective is presumably that the BSc in politics overlaps with at least twelve other BSc programmes containing politics as a constituent part. The way educational programmes are set up at LSE is arguably too different to make comparisons with Gothenburg meaningful. This is even more true for the MA programmes, which are one year long rather than two years. Thus, we do not discuss LSE's MA programme below.

3.4 Oslo

The BA programme in Oslo is mostly taught in Norwegian and admits around 149 students each fall. It requires taking 90 credits in political science and 40 credits in other disciplines (not limited to social science). The programme gives students freedom in how they sequence courses, but a possible setup is found in table 8.

The shaded courses are a peculiarity in the Norwegian higher education system. These are courses that all students are expected to take to be eligible for an academic degree. Examen facultatum is largely a course in the philosophy of science, whereas Examen philosophicum is a course in epistemology and ethics (both normative ethics and metaethics). Since these are not translatable to Swedish academia, we shall not comment on them further.

A few things stand out about the programme in Oslo. One is the high degree of choice it accords students. The electives in political science allow students to specialize. More specifically, the students are expected to choose two out of the four main subfields in political science – political theory, international politics, comparative politics, and government and public administration – and then choose two courses from each of those two fields. The programme in Oslo, then, allows for specialization but not in the sense that students can choose to study just one subfield.

Table 8 Structure of the BA programme in Political Science, University of Oslo

1 st semester	Political analysis I: research design and qualitative methods (10 ECTS)	Political theory (10 ECTS)	Government and public administration (10 ECTS)
2 nd semester	Political analysis II: research design and quantitative methods (10 ECTS)	Comparative politics (10 ECTS)	Examen facultatum (10 ECTS)
3 rd semester	Examen philosophicum (10 ECTS)	International politics (10 ECTS)	Elective course (not political science, 10 ECTS)
4 th semester	Elective courses or Studies abroad		
5 th semester	Elective course in political science (10 ECTS)	Elective course in political science (10 ECTS)	Elective course (not political science, 10 ECTS)
6 th semester	Bachelor thesis (10 ECTS)	Elective course (not political science, 10 ECTS)	Elective course (not political science, 10 ECTS)

Source: <https://www.uio.no/studier/program/statsvitenskap/oppbygging/>

Another noteworthy feature is that the programme allows extraordinary freedom in the choice of non-political science courses. There is no formal requirement that these must come from adjacent social scientific fields. At the time of writing, the webpage in Oslo displayed 127 possible subjects, including ones in the humanities or natural science. In addition to this, one semester is devoted to either freely chosen elective courses (“fritt emne”) or studies abroad. Having a BA from Oslo, then, can mean very different things.

The programme contains two compulsory methods courses, one qualitative and one quantitative. The qualitative course teaches research design, case selection, analysis, etc. Using R, the quantitative course teaches research design, descriptive statistics and regression. It is organized around the idea of causal inference. Worth noting is that only 10 ECTS are devoted to the BA thesis.

3.5 Bergen

The BA programme in Comparative Politics at University of Bergen is mainly taught in Norwegian and admits 100-140 students every fall. All courses during a semester run parallel which means students take three courses at the same time. This structure also applies to the sixth semester when the students, among other things, writes their BA theses. Like several of the programmes in Sweden included in our comparison, students from other programmes can also participate in the courses held by the department and the actual number of students is often between 200 and 250.

The Comparative politics BA programme consists of six semesters, and four of these semesters are devoted to comparative politics and two semesters are for elective subjects, exchange studies, or internship. Like at Oslo, all students regardless of subject need to take the course Exam philosophicum. The two first courses in comparative politics introduces political ideology and state and nation building respectively.

Table 9 Structure of the BA programme in Comparative Politics, University of Bergen

1 st semester	Exam philosophicum, 10 credits Introduction to political ideology, 10 credits State and nation building, 10 credits
2 nd semester	Political institutions in established democracies, 10 credits Political mobilization, 10 credits Qualitative methods, 10 credits
3 rd semester	Democracy and democratization, 10 credits (course taught in English) Quantitative methods, 10 credits Semi-elective course at the “200 level”, 10 credits
4 th semester	Elective subject/exchange studies/internship, 30 credits
5 th semester	Elective subject/exchange studies/internship, 30 credits
6 th semester	Bachelor’s thesis in Comparative politics, 10 credits Two semi-elective courses at the “200 level”, 20 credits

Source: <https://www.uib.no/studier/BASV-SAPO>

Comment: List of elective courses (the so called “200 courses” based on that the course codes are SAMPOL2XX): Comparative arctic indigenous governance, Varieties of political regimes: Latin America in comparative perspective, Regions, federalism and EU integration, Political economy, Labour market policies in comparative perspective, Democratic transformations in Europe: trends and implications, Rule of law: courts and judges (in Norwegian), Populism and its consequences for liberal democracy, Party politics in Europe and beyond, Russian politics, Defence and total defence in established democracies (in Norwegian), Youth and politics, The politics and global governance of international protection, The politics of environment, American government and politics. Of the 15 “200 courses”, 13 are taught in English.

The second semester includes the courses Political Institutions in Established Democracies, Political Mobilization, and a first course in research methods, more specifically qualitative research methods. During the third semester, students take Democracy and Democratization, Quantitative Methods, and one semi-elective course. The fourth and fifth semester provides the students with the opportunity to study another subject, to do internship or exchange studies. During the final semester, the students take two semi-electives and writes their BA thesis.

The quantitative method course includes elements of research design, statistical inference, causality vs correlation, data collection, descriptive statistics, correlations, and regression analysis. The statistical software used is R.

Noteworthy is the number of substantive courses – the students get a solid training in comparative politics. The list of semi-electives is also impressive, and in some of these courses, students also practice empirical elements. Students take 20 credits of research methods, 10 credits in qualitative methods (this course is administrated by the sociology department) and 10 credits quantitative methods. As in Oslo, the BA thesis only comprises 10 credits.

3.6 Comparison between Gothenburg and the foreign BA programmes

The most striking thing about the comparison between Gothenburg and the foreign departments included here is that Gothenburg gives the students the least freedom of choice when it comes to substantive courses in political science. While Gothenburg, as noted above, allows a greater freedom to choose a minor than some of these other departments, it does not offer a comparable freedom of choice when it comes to tailoring a political science education which fits the students’ particular interests.

The freedom of choice is most pronounced in Amsterdam and, in particular, LSE. These departments offer students an impressively diverse range of courses to choose between. However, even in more comparable programmes such as that offered at Oslo, there is considerably more freedom of choice. Aarhus is arguably the one which resembles Gothenburg the most, although this programme in a sense forces an economics minor on all students (which is in itself somewhat surprising considering that Aarhus also offers a joint BA programme in politics and economics, with the department of political science collaborating with the dept. of economics). Aarhus does allow quite a diverse range of courses the one time it does allow students to choose.

It is interesting to reflect on this in two different ways: why Gothenburg has comparatively little freedom of choice and whether it would be desirable to increase it. When it comes to the “why”-question, it is striking that two authors of this report (Göran and Maria) studied political science at both the BA and MA levels at Gothenburg during a time when freedom of choice was greater. This might to some extent be explained by the lack of a programme back then, combined with it being a pre-Bologna setting. However, even within a programme structure, there are technical workarounds. A possible if inelegant approach is the semi-elective route taken under the heading of Tematisk fördjupning at Gothenburg.

One obvious issue is resources. Amsterdam and LSE take hefty tuition fees, so it should not come as a surprise that they can afford to run more courses. Another issue is the number of students: if Gothenburg would accept 300 students (like Aarhus) or 600 students (like Amsterdam) each fall, this would presumably be able to support a greater number of courses. Still, it might be worth reaching out to Oslo to hear about how they have managed to inject so many electives despite “only” accepting 149 students per annum. Is this because financing per head is more generous in Norway or is it because the courses are offered on many programmes besides the one in political science, allowing for economics of scale?

Regarding the “would it be desirable”-question, this requires making a distinction between whether more choice would be liked by the students and whether it would be in their interest. One obvious argument *against* freedom of choice is that mandatory courses ensure that the students learn what the department considers, after a process of careful curation, the most important bits of political science. It is not automatically the case that choice should be promoted just because it is requested by the students. A potential middle ground could be to move (or rather, move back considering that this is what studies in Gothenburg used to be like) to a situation where students are able to choose between taking two of the four major subfields of political science each semester. Another dimension to consider, however, is whether the teaching staff would find it desirable. Our guess is that teachers would appreciate being able to teach specialized courses on topics on which they are experts.

In terms of the substance of the programmes, there are no striking differences, at least not among mandatory courses. Different departments offer a slightly different balance between the four subfields and have different points of emphasis, but overall, they recognizably teach the same subject. The methods courses are, as far as we can see, quite comparable although Aarhus seem to put the most emphasis on methods for causal inference.

4. Swedish Master's programmes in Political Science

In this section, we cover the master's programmes at Gothenburg, Lund, Stockholm, and Uppsala.

4.1 Gothenburg

The MA programme in Gothenburg is taught in English and admits around 40 students each fall, of which around 25 register and start the programme¹⁰. The programme has a sibling in the Master's programme in Political Science: Environmental Governance and Behaviour which has about the same number of students. As the two programmes start with the same course, the "class" of 2024 consisted of 49 students of which five were international students paying tuition fees. The program can also be studied as a double degree with University of Konstanz. To be eligible for the programme, the student needs a BA degree of 180 credits, with at least 60 credits in political science or equivalent. The selection of students is based on a so-called statement of intent¹¹.

Table 10 Structure of the MA programme in Political Science, University of Gothenburg

1 st semester	Political Science Analysis (15 credits)	Research methods (15 credits) choose between four different courses
2 nd semester	The Quality of government in a comparative perspective (15 credits) <i>or</i> Citizens, politicians and the media (15 credits) <i>or</i> Environmental problems within social science: From tragedy of the commons to planetary boundaries (15 credits)	Varieties of democracy and democratization (15 credits) <i>or</i> Environmental politics and institutions (15 credits)
3 rd semester option 1	Elective courses*/Exchange studies/Internship (30 credits)	
3 rd semester option 2	The performance of democracies (15 credits) <i>or</i> European Energy and Environment (15 credits)	Research methods (15 credits): choose between four different courses (minus the course the student already has taken) <i>or</i> Internship (15 credits)
4 th semester	MA thesis (30 credits)	

Source: <https://www.gu.se/sites/default/files/2024-03/S2PSC%20eng.pdf>

Comment: The method courses consist of two qualitative courses and two quantitative courses: Courses where no previous methods training is necessary: Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists (quant) or Applied Qualitative Research Methods, Problems and Design (qual). Courses where previous methods training is necessary: Applied Qualitative Research Methods (qual, sociology department) or Applied Statistical Analysis (quant)

The programme starts with the course Political science analysis, which introduces five sub-fields: political theory; political behaviour; comparative politics; public administration; and

¹⁰ It is mainly admitted international students that don't register for the programme.

¹¹ The selection process will from 2025 also include a writing sample, such as a BA thesis or a course paper.

international politics. For the second course, students choose between four method courses, two qualitative courses, which differ in terms of what methods that are emphasised, and two quantitative methods, where one is for students with no/little previous training in methods and one for students with previous training in statistical methods. The second semester is devoted to in-depth substantive courses. During the first half of the semester, students choose between three courses (Quality of Government in a Comparative Perspective; Citizens, Politicians and the Media; or Environmental Problems within Social Science) and during the second half, students choose between two courses (Varieties of Democracy and Democratization and Environmental Politics and Institutions). During the third semester, students can take elective courses, do internship, exchange studies, or one additional method course. The final semester is devoted to the MA thesis.

It is noteworthy that programme structure is comparably fixed, and that the choice of semi-electives often is between two or three courses only. A feature that stands out is that students can choose between four different method courses, and that each course focuses on either qualitative or quantitative methods. The courses differ in terms of eligibility criteria and content.

The summarized content of the four method courses¹² is as follows:

No previous methods training needed:

SF2324 Introduction to Applied Research Design and Quantitative Research Methods for Social Scientists is divided into four blocks and six assignments: 1) Research design and scientific method, 2) Key concepts, Measurement, Central tendency, Hypothesis testing part A and Introduction to Stata and 3) Regression analysis, hypothesis testing part B, and 4) Final paper. Assignment 1 is about research design, assignment 2-5 are lab assignments on different statistical procedures in Stata. The course ends with an independently produced final paper (assignment 6) where the student designs a study and conducts preliminary statistical analyses on available data using the tools provided throughout the course

SF2323 Applied Qualitative Research Methods, problems and design is divided into three main blocks: 1) Research questions, research design, and research ethics; 2) Data collection, analysis, and interpretation (interviews, observations, qualitative content analysis¹³, and discourse analysis) and 3) Research plan. In the second block, four methods are introduced, and students choose between interviews or observations for the first assignment in this block and between qualitative content analysis and discourse analysis for the second assignment.

Previous method training necessary:

SF2321 Applied Statistical Analysis starts with lectures and a smaller 1) assignment on design for causal inference. After this, it introduces the software Stata. The course then continues with two workshops on linear regression: Introduction to linear regression and Heterogenous effects in linear regression. Then follows three workshops on applied methods for causal inference: panel regression, difference-in-difference, and synthetic controls. The course ends with an independently produced methods paper.

¹² Information retrieved from course guides. The formal course syllabi are: <https://kursplaner.gu.se/pdf/kurs/en/SF2324>, <https://kursplaner.gu.se/pdf/kurs/en/SF2323>, <https://kursplaner.gu.se/pdf/kurs/en/SF2321.pdf> and <https://kursplaner.gu.se/pdf/kurs/en/SF2322.pdf>

¹³ In the course guide from Fall 2023, qualitative content analysis is labelled typology analysis.

SF2322 *Applied Qualitative Research Methods* (administrated by the sociology department) has four modules that follows the different steps in the research process: 1) problem formulation, 2) design and data collection, 3) analyzing collected/produced material and 4) the final research product. Students have the possibility to choose between four different qualitative methods: Discourse analysis, Interviews, Ethnographic observations and Case studies.

4.2 Lund

The MA programme in Lund is taught in Swedish and admits 30-40 students each fall semester. The programme leads to a *Degree of Master of Science with a major in Political Science*.¹⁴ To be eligible for the programme, the student needs a BA degree with 90 credits political science or peace and conflict studies or equivalent as well is proficiency in English (English 6) and Swedish (Swedish 3). Noteworthy is that the selection to the programme is based on the students' grades on their bachelor thesis as well as grades on previous courses at the BA level. Lund also offers two specialized master's programmes that are taught in English (European affairs and Welfare policies and management)

Table 11 Programme structure, MA programme in Political Science, Lund University

1 st semester	Politisk ordning i tid och rum (15 credits)	Methods (15 credits)
2 nd semester	Choose a course from the subject field political science (15 credits) and elective courses in political science or other fields, (45 credits, minimum 15 credits on advanced level)/Internship (30 credits)/Exchange studies (30 credits)	
3 rd semester		
4 th semester		
	Thesis course (30 credits)	

Source: <https://lubas-uplan.lu.se/utbildningsplaner/pdf/id/0457a09f-5e4f-41f2-99d1-691c9a22b311?lang=swe>
 Comment: Selection of semi-elective courses from the subject field political science: European Governance, Jämförande politik - Institutioner och aktörer; Krig och fred i en föränderlig värld; Makt, politik och miljö; Minoriteter och etnisk-sekteristisk konflikt i Mellanöstern; Ontologiska säkerhetsstudier; Policyprocesser - aktörer, drivkrafter och konsekvenser

For students in Lund, 30 credits in political science, 15 credits in research methods and 30 credits thesis work are mandatory (see table 11). This gives students 45 flexible credits. 15 of these credits should be on the advanced level. The remaining 30 credits could be an internship or exchange studies.

In Lund, all students are offered the same methods course that includes both qualitative and quantitative research methods. The course includes research design and data collection techniques and analysis of interviews, questionnaires, observations and databases and these are taught using a combination of lectures and practical workshops. The forms of examination or assessment are "(1) a written and oral presentation of an assigned research problem, (2) practical and written workshop assignments, and (3) active participation".¹⁵

A noteworthy feature of the MA programme in Lund is the degree of choice during semester two and three, and that the department offers seven different semi-elective courses.

¹⁴ Filosofie masterexamen, and not politics masterexamen.

¹⁵ <https://kursplaner.lu.se/pdf/kurs/sv/STVN14>

4.3 Stockholm

The MA programmes in Stockholm has one admission in Swedish and one in English. They admit 35 students to each version. The two programmes in Stockholm are identical except for the language of instruction. The programme leads to a *Master's degree in Political Science*. The department also offers four additional master's programmes, and one is a double-degree option with Ludwig Maximilian University in Munich. To be eligible for the programme, the student needs a BA degree of 180 credits, with at least 90 credits in political science, or equivalent. Proficiency in English is also necessary (English 6 or equivalent). The selection of students is based on grades on previous university courses.

The first semester consists of a 15 credits course called Analytical perspectives and the study of power in social science followed by two semi-elective courses of 7,5 credits each. During the second semester, students take Analysis of democracy, followed by yet another semi-elective course and 15 credits of research methods. There are three to four semi-elective courses to choose between for every period. In summary, SU students take three semi-elective courses throughout their MA program out of eleven available courses. The MA thesis is written during the third semester. The final semester is for elective courses, internship, or exchange studies. The department seems to emphasize the internship courses, but also writes that it is possible to study abroad and/or choose elective courses in consultation with the director of studies. We cannot find any information about whether it is possible to invert the order of semesters three and four.

Table 12 Programme structure, MA programme in Political Science/International Master's Programme in Political Science, Stockholm University

1 st semester	Analytical Perspectives and the Study of Power in Social Science (15 credits)	Semi-elective course*: political science (7,5)	Semi-elective course**: political science (7,5 credits)
2 nd semester	Analysis of Democracy, (7,5 credits)	Semi-elective course*** (7,5 credits)	Methods (15 credits) Qualitative Methods <i>or</i> Quantitative Methods
3 rd semester	Thesis course (30 credits)		
4 th semester	Elective courses/Internship/exchange studies on advanced level		

Source: <https://www.su.se/sok-kurser-och-program/sposo-1.411790?open-collapse-boxes=>

Comment: Semi-elective courses*: Politics of Equality; Institutioner och politisk kultur i Sverige; International Security Politics; and Populism and Democratic Politics. Semi elective courses**: EU som politiskt system; Global and Regional Governance; National and Global Equality Policies; and Environmental Politics - Governing the Anthropocene from Local to Global. Semi-elective courses***: Democratization and Autocratization; International Political Theory; and Global Climate and Environmental Politics.

Worth noting is that Stockholm is the only Swedish political science department in our comparison that offers the methods course during the second semester. The other three offer it during the first semester. In Stockholm, students choose between a qualitative or a quantitative method course. The qualitative method course includes process tracing, discourse analysis, analysis of ideas and political ethnography. The quantitative method course teaches students in descriptive statistics, statistical inference, regression analysis, time-series analysis, and experimental methods. It seems possible to take a second methods course as elective course

during the fourth semester. However, since methods courses are given in the spring semester, this means that students would take the second method course *after* having written their thesis.

4.4 Uppsala

The master's programme in Uppsala is taught in English and admits 55-75 students each fall. Degree-wise, the programme leads to a *Master of Science in Political Sciences* (120 credits) with Political Science or Development Studies as the main field of study. Students need a BA degree with 90 credits in political science or equivalent, including independent academic work, for example a BA thesis, of at least 8000 words to be eligible for the program. Proficiency in English (English 6, or equivalent) is also necessary.

Students have three mandatory courses during semester 1 and 3; all other courses are electives (see table 13). The students can change the order of the third and fourth semester. Unusually, students in Uppsala don't take a common course as the first course of the program. Instead, they choose between three courses. The second course on the first semester is the Methods course.

Table 13 Programme structure, MA programme in Political Science, Uppsala University

1 st semester	International Politics (15 credits) or Governance and The State (15 credits) or The Politics of Development (15 credits)	Methods (15 credits)
2 nd semester	Elective courses: additional political science or courses at affiliated departments, other courses at UU or in Sweden or elsewhere (30 credits)	
3 rd semester	Master's thesis (30 credits)	
4 th semester	Elective courses/internship in Sweden or abroad (30 credits)	

Source: <https://www.uu.se/utbildning/program/politices-masterprogram.html>

Comment: We have not found information on the website about the semi-elective courses in political science or development studies that are possible to choose during semester 2.

The methods course is 15 credits and gives students an introduction to both qualitative and quantitative methods. The quantitative part focuses on how to analyse causal relationships with experimental or observational data. Most of the elective courses within political science and development studies are given during the spring semester only. The elective courses during the second semester and fourth semester don't have any requirements on subject area.

What stands out with the Uppsala programme is its flexibility as semesters two, three and four make it possible for students to tailor the programme. This opens possibilities for students that want to fit in both exchange studies and internship during their two years of studies, but a downside is that the only common compulsory course might be the one on methods.

5. Foreign Master's programmes in Political Science

5.1 Aarhus

The MA programme in Aarhus is a Danish-speaking one, although many individual courses are given in English. There was an English-speaking version of the programme earlier, but this was cancelled 2022 due to a political decision. However, there are current attempts to increase the number of English-speaking programmes in Denmark, so it is not impossible that an English version of the programme will return. Around 200 students are admitted each fall.

The programme includes, somewhat oddly, a compulsory course on public law and the bureaucracy (see table 14). This is a practically oriented course in which students are taught the organization of the public administration of Denmark, with an emphasis on the rights of citizens. This, then, reflects an ambition to ensure that the students are equipped to take jobs in public agencies or other parts of the Danish bureaucracy.

Table 14 Programme structure, MA programme in Political Science/International Master's Programme in Political Science, Aarhus University

1 st semester	Public administration (Förvaltningsrätt, 10 ECTS)	Seminars (20 ECTS)
2 nd semester	Seminars (30 ECTS)	
3 rd semester	Seminars (30 ECTS) <i>or</i> Seminars (10/20 ECTS) and internship (10/20 ECTS)	
4 th semester	Master thesis	

Source: <https://kandidat.au.dk/statskundskab/>

Apart from this, what stands out about the programme is the very high degree of choice. The department supplies a long list of courses, either 10 or 20 ECTS, to choose between, meaning that students can tailor their education to suit their interests. In fall 2023, for example, the department offered 38 different courses. This is feasible given that the program admits around 200 students. The way the electives is organized is that sections in the department (e.g., the comparative politics section among the faculty) are tasked with submitting a given number of courses and then allocate the task to teachers in the section. The teachers are then free to design their own courses, which are given, or not, depending on if they are chosen by a sufficient number of students (around 20 students). The seminars are taught weekly or bi-weekly and are a mix of lectures and discussions based on readings.

In terms of the substantive content, students are expected to take at least 50 ECTS worth of political science seminars. There is no requirement to take seminars in other branches of social science, but students can take up to 30 ECTS worth of these. Worth noting is that the programme does not require taking methods seminars, though such seminars are available (in fall 2023, for example, six methods seminars were offered: case studies; Bayesian statistics;

political data science; surveys and survey experiments; qualitative methodology; and computer-assisted analysis of texts, audio and images).

5.2 Oslo

The MA Programme in Political Science in Oslo is a two-year, English-speaking programme, which admits around 120 students each fall. To be eligible for the programme, the student needs to be a Norwegian or EU citizen or have a permanent or renewable residency permit in Norway. The student also needs grade C on their BA degree, of which 80 credits must be in political science.¹⁶

The thing that stands out most here is the complete absence of compulsory substantive courses – the mandatory courses are all related to method/design or the master thesis (see table 15). The elective courses on the 1st or 2nd semester do not have to be in political science, but the department offers a considerable number of specialized courses (at the time of writing, about 45 of them) belonging to different subfields in political science. There is also an opportunity to do an internship instead of taking a 10-credit course.

Table 15 Programme structure, MA programme in Political Science, Oslo University

1 st semester	Research design in political science (10 ECTS)	Applied statistics for political science (10 ECTS)	Elective course (10 ECTS)
2 nd semester	Elective courses <i>or</i> Studies abroad (30 ECTS)		
3 rd semester	Elective methods course (10 ECTS)	Master thesis course (5 ECTS)	Master thesis (15 of 45 ECTS)
4 th semester	Master thesis (30 of 45 ECTS)		

Source: <https://www.uio.no/studier/program/statsvitenskap-master/oppbygging/>

Another noteworthy feature is the fact that the master thesis spans two semesters and is worth 45 credits. The 3rd semester leads up to the master thesis. The students are here expected to first choose one out of three methods courses: Digital data in political science; Qualitative Data in Political Science; or Survey Design for Political Scientists. This is then followed by a small (5 ECTS) course on thesis design and project management, in which students get feedback on their planned theses.

In terms of the non-elective methods courses, the research design course is largely aimed at drawing conclusions, be they descriptive, causal, or predictive. It covers qualitative as well as quantitative research designs and contains a segment of research ethics. The ambition, unsurprisingly, is to enable students to create their own design in addition to criticizing the design of others. The course on applied statistics, meanwhile, focuses on causal inference. Using R, it covers regression analysis and generalized linear models.

¹⁶ To be eligible, the political science education must cover three of four sub-disciplines (political theory, international politics, comparative politics, and public administration). At least 20 credits need to be in-depth courses and at least 10 credits needs to be in statistical methods. Finally, a BA thesis in political science is also necessary to be eligible.

5.3 Bergen

The MA programme in Comparative politics at University of Bergen requires proficiency in Norwegian, and the courses offered are a mix of courses taught in Norwegian and English. Around 30 students are admitted each year. To be eligible for the programme, the students need at least a C grade from BA level program in Political Science (in Norway). The courses during a semester run parallel.

The Comparative politics master starts with two courses, a research method course on multivariate data analysis and a so-called master's seminar in comparative politics (see table 16). The latter course deepens the student's knowledge about the key themes in comparative politics and combines the historical development within the field with today's research front, which is similar to how the GU course Political Science Analysis is organized, although the latter introduces five sub-disciplines. The master's seminar course also teaches how theory can be used to explain empirical relationships (independent and dependent variable). The students learn how to synthesize and criticize previous research and how to find research gaps.

Table 16 Programme structure, MA programme in Comparative Politics, University of Bergen

1 st semester	Multivariate data analysis, 15 credits Master's seminar in comparative politics, 15 credits
2 nd semester	Research design and qualitative methods, 10 credits Semi-elective course, 10 credits Semi-elective, 10 credits
3 rd & 4 th semester	Master's thesis (60 credits)

Source: <https://www.uib.no/studier/MASV-SAPO>

Comment: List of semi-elective courses: New Forms of Governance in the Nordic region; Advanced Quantitative Analysis; Distributive Justice; Local and Regional Democracy in Multilevel Norway and Europe (In English); Globalization and the Geopolitics of Forced Migration (in English); Arctic Politics (in English); Political Inequality in Democracy (in English); and Comparative Judicial Behaviour.

The research method course teaches data collection and various regression techniques such as linear regression, panel regression, logistic regression, and multi-level regression. The statistical software used is R. The second semester includes one additional research method course, but this course instead includes research design and qualitative methods. The students also choose two (of eight) semi-elective courses, and one of the elective courses is Advanced quantitative analysis (causal inference and Bayesian models). Students can also choose to do exchange studies during the second semester. The master's programme ends with a one-year master's thesis in comparative politics.

It is noteworthy that master's students in Bergen as a minimum has 25 credits research methods, with the possibility of adding additional 10 credits. What especially stands out is the one-year MA thesis. In Bergen, a MA student is integrated with the research group that fits his or her interest, and also presents parts of the thesis for the research group. Many MA students also work as teaching assistants on the BA programme.

5.4 Comparison between the MA programmes

In Sweden, it should first be noted that only the MA programme at Lund is in Swedish. The programmes Gothenburg and Uppsala are English-speaking, while the Stockholm offers their programme both in Swedish and English. Among the Scandinavian universities, the Aarhus and Bergen programmes requires proficiency in Danish and Norwegian respectively. The Oslo programme is English-speaking, but it is not open for students outside EU, unless they already have a residency permit in Norway. This means that the student groups studying on the different programmes likely differs a lot.

The eligibility criteria differ between the programmes. Looking at the Swedish programmes, Lund, Stockholm and Uppsala all require a BA degree with 90 credits political science or equivalent, while GU only demands 60 credits. Lund and Uppsala require applicants to submit their BA thesis or equivalent written assignment; Lund also takes the grades on BA courses into consideration. Stockholm only admits based on grades. GU is the only programme in Sweden that requires a Statement of intent/letter from the applicant.

The admission process is currently being reviewed at GU. Considering that GU is the only Swedish university among the four we compared that explicitly offers students to study *more* than 90 credits political science at the BA level, the lower entry requirement to the MA programme in terms of courses in the main discipline – i.e., 60 credits worth of political science -- stands out (we are aware of that the programme is international and recruits much wider than from our own BA programme).

When comparing the MA programmes in Sweden, the overall impression is that they are quite similar. The main differences are, apart from the substantive courses taught, whether there are separate courses for qualitative and quantitative methods as well as the timing of the methods courses. GU and Stockholm have specialized method courses (quantitative *or* qualitative methods) while Lund and Uppsala teach qualitative and quantitative methods in the same course. GU has a larger range of method courses to choose from than the others. Moreover, students at GU can take an additional method course during their third semester, but few do. As for the timing, all programmes except Stockholm offer methods during the first semester.

When it comes to the degree of choice accorded the students, the programmes are comparable. Whereas GU stood out as offering few elective courses at the BA level, this is not the case for the MA level in a Swedish comparison. If we include internship and exchange studies in the set of elective courses, GU has 90 elective credits. Uppsala has 75, Stockholm has 67.5, and Lund has 60. Having said that, Uppsala's programme is the most flexible. It seems that a student can study this program and only take one course (15 credits) of substantive political science, except for the thesis (the thesis can also be written within development studies.) When it comes to the format of the courses, GU's tendency to offer 15 credit courses does not stand out in a Swedish comparison. However, Stockholm works much more with 7,5-point courses. All Swedish MA programmes offer the possibility to include internship semester.

When it comes to the international comparison, we believe the useful thing to reflect on is the degree of choice accorded by Oslo and, above all, Aarhus. The programme in Aarhus has only one mandatory course; everything else is electives, and there is not even a formal requirement

to take methods. Moreover, this is paired with a rich menu of courses from which to choose. Having a MA from Aarhus can mean quite different things.

The issue this raises is, as we noted in chapter 3, what kind of programme would be ideal. Again, as one can think of it as a dimension where one end point (close to Aarhus) is no mandatory courses, and the other end point (close to MAPSE) is only mandatory courses. The former might be called the “choice model” and the latter the “curation model”. While the direction of a department’s study programmes is largely dictated by resources, it is still worth reflecting on the choice between these models because it can give some direction as to shaping the department’s educational philosophy. Does it make more sense to guide the student through a carefully curated series of the most essential insights from political science, or should the student rather have the opportunity to delve into the particular issues he or she finds interesting? The answer is not obvious. Of course, a middle ground between the choice and curation models is also possible, but it is still worth reflecting on the direction of travel in a principled way. Again, such reflection must be careful to disentangle the interests or wishes of the students from the interests or wishes of the teachers since it is not obvious that these always line up.

As for methods specifically, Oslo has 30 credits worth of compulsory courses in research methods and Bergen has 25 credits. Thus, these universities exceed all four Swedish universities in terms of compulsory method courses. Aarhus, on the other hand, requires no methods courses, but offer students many to choose between (at the time of writing, six) and there is an informal norm among students to take at least one. Aarhus, Bergen and Oslo all strongly emphasize statistical methods.

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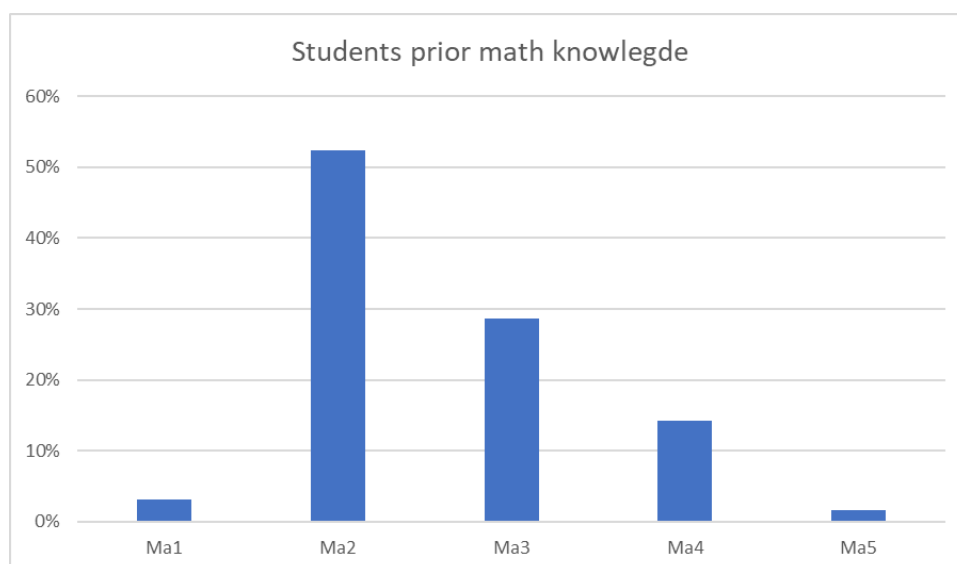
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Appendix

Eligibility

The other Swedish bachelor programmes in Political Science has a requirement of Mathematics level 3, while we only require basic eligibility which, among other things, means at least Mathematics 1 for students who has a degree from upper secondary school from 2016 and onwards. This made us curious about what level of mathematics our students have. The below table shows the five levels of mathematics and which level the group of students admitted to the programme fall 2023 has. More than half of the students attending our Bachelor programme today wouldn't be qualified for the programme if we increased the admission requirements in mathematics to level 3 (which is the requirement in Lund, Stockholm and Uppsala since Economics is compulsory subject within these programmes). In addition, they wouldn't qualify for the other Swedish Bachelor programmes in political science either.

Figure A1 Prior knowledge in Mathematics among students admitted to the BA program in political science, GU, fall 2023 (percent).



Source: NyA-webben, manual check of our admitted students math competence, [NyA-webben \(antagning.se\)](https://antagning.se) (authorization required).

19 percent (12 of 63) have a math course indicating that they have a degree from programmes such as the Science programme (Naturvetenskapliga programmet), that is Mathematics level 4 or more.

8 percent (5 of 63) have a math course indicating that they attended a vocational programme, such as the Vehicle and transportation programme (Fordon och Transport programmet) or the nursing programme (Vård- och omsorgsprogrammet). In the figure, we have collapsed the different math courses (math courses on vocational programs are called Matematik 1a, 2a, in social science/economics/humanities/arts, they are called 1b, 2b and in science and technology, they are called 1c, 2c and so on).

73 percent (46 of 63) have a math course indicating they attended a programme such as social science or economics. On these programs, Mathematics 2 is compulsory.

55,5 percent (35 of 63) don't have a higher level than Mathematics 2

Admission results

Table A1 Admission results for political science programs at the four largest Swedish universities, fall semester admission round 2023

University	BI	BII	HP
GU	20,18	19,71	1,15
LU	20,21	20,65	1,25
SU	17,08	18,67	0,90
UU	20,57	21,55	1,30

Source: www.uhr.se

Comment: Admission group BI – students applying on their “Gymnasieexamen”, Admission group BII – students applying with supplemented grades/courses, Admission group HP – students applying on the Högskoleprovet - (Swedish Scholastic Aptitude Test (SweSAT), max score is 2,0)

The admission scores for BI, students with degree from upper secondary school, are very similar for GU and LU (around 20,2), slightly higher at UU (20,57), and considerably lower for SU (17,08). LU and UU have higher admission scores for Högskoleprovet (1,25 and 1,3) than both GU (1,15) and SU (0,9).

In the Swedish system, maximum grade score is 20 (=A in all subjects) and this can be increased to with maximum 2,5 points to 22,5 depending on what courses you have studied during upper secondary school. Modern languages (max +1,5 points), English 7 (+1 point) and Mathematics (max +1,5 points) are the courses that gives bonus merits points. For Mathematics, the number of bonus points is set in relation to the eligibility criteria for the university programme or courses you have applied for.

It should therefore be noted that students with more than Maths 1 applying to political science GU potentially get bonus merit points for Mathematics 2 and above (0,5 points per course for level 2-4, 1 point for Math 5, but never more than +1,5 points all together) while only students with Mathematics 4 or more would receive bonus merit points when applying to LU, SU or UU. To take an example: All else equal, if a student with Mathematics 3 both applies to LU and GU, he or she could get up to 1 merit point more and thus a higher grade in the admission to GU but not at LU. However, as stated above, there are different ways to reach the +2,5 extra merits scores (modern languages and English 7). In summary, it is hard to assess whether the GU admission grades are a result of that more applicants gets bonus merits points for maths compared to LU, SU and UU.